Session 10: Emotional Intelligence & Objection Handling

Sales 101 (Postgraduate) | What Happens After You Win the Deal | 90 minutes

Class Agenda

Time	What we are doing	What you produce
0-04	Objectives and how you will know you got there	Nothing. Read the success criteria.
04-16	EI in sales: self-awareness, empathy, reading the room	Notes.
16-26	Four archetypes under pressure, and what each needs	Notes.
26-36	Acknowledge, Probe, Reframe, Respond. Real objection or smokescreen.	Notes.
36-40	The case, and your rotation	None.
40-78	Six live scenarios. Three minutes each, rotating.	Six observer feedback rounds.
78-85	Debrief: when empathy works, when data works	Discussion.
85-90	Self-check and closing questions	Answer sheet, handed in.

Key Objectives

#	Objective	What success looks like	Where it is measured
LO1	Handle a hostile or sceptical counterpart without becoming defensive.	You get through a hostile scenario without justifying, arguing, or matching their temperature. Your observer confirms it.	Scenarios 1 and 4.
LO2	Use Acknowledge, Probe, Reframe, Respond on a live objection.	All four steps present and in order, out loud, in real time. You do not skip straight to Respond.	All six scenarios. Observer-scored.
LO3	Adjust your approach to the archetype in front of you.	You can name which archetype each scenario put you in front of, and say what you did differently as a result.	Self-check and debrief.
LO4	Tell a real objection from a smokescreen.	In at least two scenarios you identify that the stated objection is not the real one, and you find the real one by asking rather than guessing.	Scenarios 2, 4 and 5.

WHY THESE SCENARIOS ARE ALL FROM ONE DEAL

Every scenario today comes from the same account, after the deal was signed. That is deliberate.

Generic objection drills teach you to recognise objection types. They do not teach you that the same relationship produces different pressure at different moments, and that the person shouting at you in month two is someone you spent six weeks persuading.

The account is Aarohan Logistics, and the full background is on the following pages. You need it in front of you.

Part 1: Emotional Intelligence in Sales

Emotional intelligence in a commercial setting is not about being nice. It is about accurate perception under pressure: reading what is actually happening in the room, including inside yourself, and choosing a response instead of producing one.

The three things it breaks down into

	What it means here	What failing at it looks like
Self-awareness	Noticing your own state before it drives your behaviour. Recognising the moment you have started defending rather than listening.	Talking faster. Interrupting. Repeating a point they already rejected, louder.
Empathy	Working out what they are experiencing, which is often not what they are saying. Distinguishing the emotion from the content.	Responding to the words and missing that the person is frightened, embarrassed, or exposed.
Reading the room	Noticing who has gone quiet, who is looking at whom, and what changed in the last thirty seconds.	Carrying on with your agenda while the actual decision is happening in glances you did not see.

The one signal to train yourself on

WHEN SOMEONE GETS ANGRY, ASK WHAT THEY ARE EXPOSED TO

Anger in a commercial relationship is almost never about you. It is usually about what the situation has cost the person in front of you — in front of their boss, their team, or their own judgement.

A founder shouting about a rejected claim is not angry about the claim. He is angry that he defended this decision and it made him look wrong.

You cannot fix the anger. You can address the exposure. Those are different responses and only one of them works.

Managing yourself

- Match content, not temperature. If they speed up, slow down. If they raise their voice, lower yours. This is a physical discipline and it is learnable.

- Three seconds before you answer anything hostile. Not to think of a better answer, but to stop the reflexive one.
- Never explain in the first sentence. The first sentence acknowledges. Explanation, if it is needed at all, comes third or fourth.
- Say the uncomfortable thing yourself before they do. 'You backed this and it hasn't worked yet, and that's on me to fix' costs you nothing and removes their entire opening.

Part 2: Four Archetypes Under Pressure

The same objection needs a different response depending on who is raising it. These four cover most of what you will meet.

Archetype	How they behave under pressure	What they actually need	What makes it worse
The Sceptic	Challenges your evidence. Asks for proof, then questions the proof. Cold rather than hot.	Something checkable. A number, a name, a document. Not reassurance.	Enthusiasm. The more confident you sound, the less they believe you.
The Champion gone cold	Stops replying. Short answers. Was your advocate and now is not.	Cover. They have been challenged internally and lost. Give them something to win the next round with.	Pressure. Chasing an unresponsive champion accelerates the loss.
The Blocker	Objects on grounds you cannot argue with: risk, compliance, precedent. Often arrives late.	To be brought in properly, early, and asked what would make this acceptable rather than told why it is fine.	Going around them. They find out, and then it becomes personal.
The Distracted Executive	Half-present. Interrupts. Asks a question you already answered. Ends the call early.	One thing, said in one sentence, and a decision they can make now.	Thoroughness. Every additional detail reduces the chance of a decision.

Part 3: Handling the Objection

Acknowledge, Probe, Reframe, Respond

Step	What you do	What it sounds like	Why it is in this position
Acknowledge	Say the objection back, without softening it and without agreeing to it.	"So a claim got rejected in month two, and you're the one who signed this off."	Nobody hears anything until they believe you heard them. Skipping this makes every later step useless.

Step	What you do	What it sounds like	Why it is in this position
Probe	Ask one question to find out what the objection actually is.	"What happened when you told the team?"	The stated objection is frequently not the operative one. This is where you find out.
Reframe	Change what the conversation is about, using what they just gave you.	"So the problem isn't the rejection — it's that you had no answer for the team for two days."	You cannot win the argument they started. You can move to one you can both act on.
Respond	Now answer. Briefly.	"Here's what I'll do about the two days."	Last, because until now you did not know what you were answering.

THE HARDEST PART IS THAT PROBE COMES SECOND

Under pressure, everyone skips to Respond. It feels like competence and it feels urgent.

The cost is that you answer the objection they said instead of the one they have, and then you have spent your credibility on the wrong problem.

One question. That is all Probe requires.

Real objection or smokescreen

Test	How to apply it	What it tells you
The free test	Ask yourself: if this cost nothing, would they still hesitate?	If yes, the price objection is a risk objection in a price costume.
The specificity test	Does the objection come with a detail attached — a date, a person, a past experience?	Real objections carry detail. Smokescreens are general, because they were assembled on the spot.
The consequence test	Ask what happens if this is not resolved. Listen to whether the answer is about them or about the company.	An objection with a personal consequence attached is real. One with only an abstract consequence is usually cover for something else.

Part 4: The Case

What was sold, and to whom

Onsurity is an employee healthcare and benefits platform for Indian SMEs, founded 2020 in Bengaluru. It provides hospitalisation cover, healthcare-at-home services, and pre and post-hospitalisation expense cover. Its distinctive feature is that it covers a mixed workforce in one plan: permanent, contract and freelance staff together, on a monthly subscription rather than an annual premium.

Aarohan Logistics is a 70-person logistics company in Pune, founded 2016. 28 people are on-role office and operations staff. 42 are contract drivers and warehouse workers, engaged month to month.

What happened before

When	What happened
March	A contract driver was hospitalised after an accident on a delivery run. He had no cover. Aarohan paid Rs 2.1 lakh out of pocket, unbudgeted. Two more drivers then asked whether they were covered.
April to May	Sneha Kulkarni, HR and Admin lead, requested quotes from Onsurity and from Plum. She recommended Onsurity, largely because Plum's claims support is a shared queue with a 24-hour response window and Onsurity offered a named escalation contact.
June	Rahul Mehta, founder, signed. 12-month term, all 70 people covered, Rs 725 per person per month, paid in arrears, dedicated onboarding for 30 days, and a named claims escalation contact.
July	Onboarding completed. All 70 enrolled.
Now — September	Two months in. Every scenario today happens in the next two weeks.

The three people

Person	Who they are	What they are exposed to
Sneha Kulkarni	HR and Admin lead, one of two people in the function. Reports to Rahul. She found and recommended Onsurity.	Her name is on this. In March she was the person a driver's wife rang and she had nothing to say. She chose this to stop that happening again.
Rahul Mehta	Founder and CEO. Signed the contract. Absorbed the Rs 2.1 lakh in March.	He approved a recurring cost on Sneha's recommendation. If it does not work he was wrong in front of his own team.
The drivers	42 contract staff, month to month. The people the cover is actually for.	They were told they are covered now. If that turns out to be conditional in ways nobody explained, the trust cost is immediate.

Part 5: The Six Scenarios

Threes. Seller, counterpart, observer. Three minutes per scenario, then ninety seconds of feedback, then rotate. You will not play all six as the seller.

#	The situation	Who you are facing
1	A driver's claim was rejected in week six on a documentation technicality. It has since been resolved, but Rahul only found out yesterday, from the driver. He is on the phone and he is angry.	Rahul. Hostile.
2	Sneha has not replied to two emails in three weeks. When you reach her she is polite, brief, and gives you nothing. Something has changed internally.	Sneha. Champion gone cold.
3	Sneha calls you at 9pm on a Sunday. A driver's wife has rung her about an admission and Sneha cannot reach the named escalation contact. She is not angry. She is distressed.	Sneha. Under acute pressure.
4	Rahul: "Plum came back at Rs 600 a head. That's Rs 1.05 lakh a year. Match it or we're moving at renewal."	Rahul. Price pressure.
5	Sneha: "I put my name on this. Two people have now told Rahul we should have gone with the cheaper option. I don't know what to say to them."	Sneha. Exposed.
6	Aarohan has hired a part-time CFO. She joins your quarterly review twenty minutes late, has not read anything, and asks why the company is paying monthly for something an insurer would do annually for less.	New CFO. Sceptical and distracted.

Observer feedback format

After each scenario, in this order, before any discussion. Ninety seconds.

WHAT? SO WHAT? NOW WHAT?

WHAT — "What I saw was _____." Quote an actual sentence. Not an impression.

SO WHAT — "The effect on the counterpart was _____." Watch their face and their body, not the seller's.

NOW WHAT — "Next time, _____." One thing. Specific.

Scenario Log

Fill one row in per scenario you play as seller.

Scenario	Which archetype was it?	Was the stated objection the real one? What was?	Which of the four steps did you skip?

Part 6: Check Your Own Learning

Objective	Check yourself	Tick
LO1: Composure	Ask your observer whether you matched their temperature at any point. You will not have noticed yourself doing it.	
LO2: All four steps	Look at your log. In how many scenarios did you skip straight to Respond? Any number above one is the habit, not an accident.	
LO3: Archetype	Name the archetype for each scenario you played, then say one thing you did differently because of it. If the answer is 'nothing', you ran the same script four times.	
LO4: Real or smokescreen	In scenario 4, was the objection about Rs 600? If you spent the three minutes on price, you answered the objection he said.	

THE MOST COMMON WAY TO FAIL THIS SESSION

You stay calm, you are polite throughout, and in every scenario your second sentence begins with an explanation.

Composure is not the same as handling. If you never asked a question, you defended a position rather than found out what the problem was.

Closing Questions

Five multiple-choice questions in the last five minutes. Individually and silently.